# Bridge Principles without UG: Projectibility, Crosslinguistic Evidence, and Linguistic Ontology

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Abstract

Crosslinguistic argument needs a warrant. If evidence from one language is made to bear on another, something has to explain why the evidence travels, and Reiss is right to press this against anyone who treats comparison as automatic. His answer is Chomskyan Universal Grammar, together with a stronger claim: deny UG and you forfeit any grounds for importing analytic categories across languages. This paper grants the methodological burden and rejects the monopoly claim. UG is one proposed licence for evidential travel, not the condition of possibility for linguistic comparison. The alternative is projectibility (what observing some features licenses us to expect about others), used as a second-order audit: name the target of an inference, the property-and-relation profile that supports it, and the conditions under which it should be localized, demoted, or rejected. On that audit, Reiss's French-English *any* example reaches only cue level, while historical-comparative reconstruction supplies a genuine non-UG warrant with vertical, causal-historical scope: common descent and regular correspondence license transfer within a family. The same discipline extends to public and distributed objects. The upshot is a pluralist realism about linguistic targets: mental grammars, public standards, usage profiles, typological comparanda, and norm-governed varieties are all real enough for inquiry once their projections and failure conditions are declared.

Keywords: Universal Grammar; projectibility; linguistic ontology; crosslinguistic evidence; bridge principles; comparative method

## 1 Introduction: Reiss's Challenge

This paper replies to Reiss's defence of armchair linguistics as empirical theoretical inquiry (Reiss, 2026). The chapter's target isn't comparison as such, but unlicensed comparison: the use of evidence from one language to analyse another without an account of why the evidence should travel. Reiss's positive answer is Chomskyan Universal Grammar (UG), understood as the genetically determined Human Language Faculty that supplies the common primitives of human languages.

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At the centre of the chapter is a Newtonian analogy. Reiss's thought is that apples, tides, and planets become a common empirical domain when mechanics supplies a shared level of analysis; likewise, English, French, Japanese, and Icelandic become mutually evidential when UG supplies the shared primitives of individual internal grammars, or I-languages. On that view, everyday language names such as *English* and *French* don't mark the scientific objects directly. The relevant objects are individual internal languages analysed against a universal inventory.

Reiss also narrows the people whose views are under discussion. His stipulation itself marks the word typographically: "the views of 'linguists' in this chapter" are the views of "Chomsky and those who broadly adopt his philosophical stances" (Reiss, 2026, sec. 2). I accept that local stipulation.

I too will employ typography. In this paper, 'linguists', with quotation marks, refers to Reiss's stipulated Chomskyan group. But LINGUISTS will refer to researchers whose work is organized around systematic inquiry into human language phenomena, including historical linguists, typologists, sociolinguists, corpus linguists, descriptive fieldworkers, language philosophers, and Chomskyan syntacticians.

My disagreement begins when the stipulation and the UG postulate are made to do global work. Reiss's conclusion isn't only that UG can license some crosslinguistic inferences within a Chomskyan programme. It says that denying UG leaves one without grounds for importing analytic categories from one language into another. That's the monopoly claim at issue here.

Reiss's monopoly claim has two faces. One is evidential: why should French evidence bear on English, or Japanese evidence on Icelandic? The other is classificatory: why are French, Warlpiri, and Swahili in the same domain of inquiry while chess, Python, and tango aren't? Reiss is right that neither question can be waved away. The mistake is to treat the need for a domain and the need for transfer as if both had already been answered by the word *UG*.

Projectibility supplies the alternative: what observing some features licenses us to expect about others (Goodman, 1955; Reynolds, 2026a). Some features support predictions; others don't. A projectibility-first linguistics asks what a proposed linguistic kind lets us infer, which profile supports that inference, and where the projection fails. Universal Grammar can be part of a proposed support story. It isn't the condition of possibility for linguistic comparison.

The argument proceeds as follows. Section 2 grants Reiss's central methodological point: crosslinguistic evidence needs a warrant. Section 3 separates domain formation, evidential transfer, and monopoly. Section 4 introduces projectibility as the audit framework for bridge principles. Section 5 explains why Reiss's restricted use of 'linguists' can't support conclusions about LINGUISTS as such. Sections 6 and 7 apply the framework, first by demoting Reiss's French-English *any* example to cue status and then by giving historical comparison as a successful non-UG warrant. Section 8 extends the same discipline to public and distributed linguistic objects.

## 2 What Reiss Gets Right

Reiss's best point is methodological. Theoretical linguistics can be empirical without being experimental, corpus-based, or statistical. Good armchair work isn't mere introspection detached from the world. It's a form of theory-mediated empirical reasoning in which judgements, contrasts, paradigms, and crosslinguistic patterns are made to bear on abstract structure.

Categories such as word, sentence, negative-polarity item, segment, syllable, and interrogative element aren't read directly from the acoustic signal, the printed page, or a spreadsheet of corpus counts. A statistician still has to know what's being counted. A corpus linguist still has to decide what counts as a token of the relevant sort. A psycholinguistic experiment still has to decide which contrast the stimuli instantiate.

Crosslinguistic evidence needs a warrant. If French data is used to analyse English, or Japanese data is used to analyse English and Icelandic, then the inference isn't justified by the mere fact that all are called languages. Reiss's examples of empirical argumentation devices put pressure on any view that treats crosslinguistic comparison as automatic.

Nor should the reply pretend that UG-style research never provides content. A Chomskyan account can offer precise hypotheses about locality, binding, polarity, category features, movement, or possible dependencies, and those hypotheses can generate crosslinguistic expectations. The objection is narrower and stronger: successful UG-shaped warrants for I-language inquiry don't establish that UG is the only possible licence, nor that every legitimate linguistic target has to be an I-language target.

These concessions narrow the dispute. The issue isn't theory, realism, armchair method, or comparison. It's whether the evidential-warrant burden has only one possible answer.

## 3 The Monopoly Claim

Reiss's monopoly claim comes from a chain of roles assigned to UG, not from one local observation. In the opening frame, UG is the innate Human Language Faculty that makes human languages a natural domain. In the discussion of empirical argumentation devices, UG is the postulate under which judgements and crosslinguistic observations count as empirical evidence. In the conclusion, UG is a background assumption, a null hypothesis, and a licence for treating each language as potentially relevant to all others (Reiss, 2026, secs. 1, 5–6). Those claims sit close together in the chapter, but they aren't equivalent.

Reiss's Newton analogy has to be kept in view. In his setup, Newton's postulate doesn't treat apples and planets as everyday objects that happen to be similar. It places them under a common theoretical description, with common primitives, measures, equations, counterfactual expectations, and conditions under which the theory would be strained. The proposed linguistic parallel is that Quechua, Hungarian, French, and English aren't the scientific objects directly; the objects are I-languages analysed with UG-supplied primitives.

So Reiss has a powerful argument for a research domain. He doesn't yet have an argument for a transfer monopoly. Three claims have to be separated: that human languages form a domain, that evidence may sometimes travel across members of that domain, and that only UG can license the travel. The first claim may be defended by a domain postulate. The second requires a transfer principle. The third requires an exclusion argument against rival warrants. Reiss's chapter often lets the first do the work of all three.

A general postulate of shared human linguistic endowment may define a research domain for 'linguists', but it doesn't by itself say which comparison is licensed, what the projection target is, how far the evidence travels, or when the inference fails. Nor does it explain why conclusions licensed inside an I-language programme should project onto historical linguists, typologists, sociolinguists, corpus linguists, descriptive fieldworkers, language philosophers, or construction grammarians. A licence that never specifies its failure conditions is too permissive to do the work Reiss assigns to it.

A familiar retreat doesn't help. If UG merely makes crosslinguistic evidence potentially relevant, the monopoly conclusion doesn't follow: potential relevance isn't a licence for any particular transfer. If, instead, a substantive UG theory licenses a particular transfer, then UG is no longer functioning as a bare domain-defining postulate. It's a first-order warrant with its own target, support, scope, and failure conditions. A thin UG postulate can't license the monopoly; a thick UG theory is one auditable warrant among others.

Once the thin/thick dilemma is visible, the Newton comparison turns against the monopoly. Physics transfer principles are answerable to scope, measures, counterfactual expectations, and breakdown conditions. Reiss's UG postulate is treated as if it also generated jurisdiction: a password that admits preferred transfers and excludes rival licences. It's asked to do the grouping work, the transfer work, and the exclusionary work at once.

A substantive UG theory may do some of that work for a particular comparison. It may predict that a dependency should be constrained by locality, that an apparent lexical item should decompose into two grammatical objects, or that a surface contrast should reflect an unpronounced structural contrast. But then the warrant comes from the specified theory, diagnostics, and failure conditions, not from the bare fact that UG has been postulated. The examples show that Chomskyan 'linguists' have found fruitful comparisons. They don't show that all legitimate comparisons require UG.

The empirical argumentation devices don't need to be rejected. Homophony, hidden structure, distributional contrast, and crosslinguistic prompts are ordinary forms of linguistic reasoning. Their legitimacy depends on the target and on the warrant that connects the prompt to the proposed analysis. A Chomskyan theory may provide such a warrant, but the device itself doesn't carry a UG credential. If the support comes from functional recurrence, diachrony, contact history, or language-internal distribution, the argument remains empirical without becoming Reiss-style UG.

Nor does the domain question force the monopoly conclusion. Human languages can be grouped by a recurring profile that supports projections without treating UG as the essence of the group. Section 4 makes PROFILE precise; here the word marks the recurring pattern that supports projection. The pattern includes productive form-interpretation pairings acquired as primary communicative systems, externalized in speech, sign, writing, or other modalities, socially transmitted and norm-governed, historically variable, and available for translation, paraphrase, repair, error, correction, and grammatical judgement. The cluster is stabilized by biological endowment, acquisition and uptake, communicative function, social transmission, norm-governed reproduction, and repair under error.

Nothing in that profile smuggles in the Chomskyan conclusion. Form-interpretation pairings and grammatical judgements presuppose grammaticality as a projectible property, not UG as its explanation. Even if a UG theory best explained part of the cluster's cohesion, that would help individuate the domain; it wouldn't license transfer from one language to another without a first-order transfer warrant.

Chess, Python, and tango share some traits with human languages. They have conventions, learnability, sequencing, and in some cases formal syntax. But they don't support the same projection package: native-language acquisition, ordinary open-ended communicative uptake, historical sound and morphosyntactic change, indexical register effects, crosslinguistic translation, and grammar-internal acceptability contrasts don't travel to them as a set. They may be valuable comparanda. They aren't thereby co-domain targets for the same linguistic projections.

Projectibility-first linguistics can ask the missing questions directly. It can distinguish a claim about mental grammars from a claim about a public standard, a corpus profile, a typological comparandum, a diachronic pathway, or an institutional norm. Reiss's 'linguists' can handle the first target on their own terms. They can't infer from that success that the other targets are illegitimate, or that LINGUISTS working on them lack grounds for comparison.

## 4 The Projectibility Framework

An evidential warrant has to say why this evidence matters for that claim. A bridge principle names the target of the inference, the pattern that makes the inference plausible, the signs that locate that pattern, and the conditions under which the inference should stop.

First fix the target. A projection is an inference from observed features to expected features: from a diagnostic pattern in the source material to a claim about some target. The target may be an individual mental grammar, a public standard, a corpus profile, a typological comparandum, a diachronic pathway, an institutional norm, or a social practice. The target matters because the same observation can licence one projection and fail to licence another.

Call the corresponding worldly pattern a PROFILE. It makes a projection worth trying because it includes properties and relations, not just shared labels. The relevant question is why observing one feature gives reason to expect another.

At minimum, the audit needs three pieces. The TARGET says what the inference is about. A DIAGNOSTIC is evidence that the profile is present. Scope conditions and defeaters say where the projection applies and what would block, localize, or demote it (Reynolds, 2026a). Later examples add a further question: what keeps the source and target properties connected rather than accidentally associated?

Those pieces support different grades of inference. A diagnostic cue identifies a candidate contrast but doesn't by itself license transfer. A scoped bridge identifies the target and support profile clearly enough to license a local projection. A robust bridge earns broader use only when it survives independent cases, held-out contrasts, and known defeaters. These grades keep cue, warrant, and scope from collapsing into one another.

A corpus frequency difference may cue a register contrast. It becomes a scoped bridge when the conditioning structure is identified and the projection survives held-out material: for instance, knowing the institutional setting predicts likely forms, and hearing the forms helps infer the setting. It becomes robust only if the same profile continues to support projections across genres, speakers, institutions, or periods while respecting declared defeaters. The point isn't to inflate every coding decision into metaphysics but to keep evidential travel inspectable.

Put schematically, a bridge principle is a scoped licence from observed diagnostics to a projected target through a proposed profile: if source features S identify profile P under conditions C, then target expectation Q is licensed until defeaters D appear. Projectibility is a second-order discipline for evaluating such warrants, not a rival language faculty. UG is one possible first-order filling of the schema. Functional recurrence, diachronic pathway, processing pressure, acquisition bottleneck, social uptake, and institutional maintenance can also fill it when they connect source and target for the declared inquiry.

Haspelmath's comparative concepts and Croft's Radical Construction Grammar already supply non-UG discipline for crosslinguistic work (Croft, 2001; Haspelmath, 2010). Comparative concepts make comparison accountable without treating every useful category as an innate universal. Radical

Construction Grammar treats categories as language-specific while preserving comparison through function and typological patterning. These approaches don't by themselves license evidential transfer, but they show that crosslinguistic discipline doesn't require a universal inventory of Chomskyan primitives.

The same discipline separates three operations. Comparison places phenomena under a declared description. Classification assigns a language-internal realization to the comparandum. Evidential transfer treats evidence about one realization as support for an analysis of another (Reynolds, 2025). The third begins only when the comparative setup is embedded in a profile with projection, support, scope, and defeaters.

## 5 Boundary Stipulation

Here the notation is a concession, not a complaint. Reiss is free to stipulate that 'linguists', in his chapter, means Chomskyan-internal theorists. Claims about 'linguists' may show what follows for that subkind. They don't automatically show what follows for LINGUISTS.

Presentation order matters. Before UG is credited with licensing field-wide evidential rights, the chapter has already marked some opponents as scholars who "self-identify as linguists" (Reiss, 2026, sec. 2). The phrase risks turning colleagues into claimants and disagreement into a question of standing. That phrasing isn't the argument, but it marks the work the argument still owes. A boundary first drawn rhetorically still needs a warrant if it's to support a field-wide conclusion.

Reiss may stipulate locally. Trouble starts when the paper lets a local stipulation do global work.

## 6 A Worked Audit: French Evidence for English Polarity

Reiss's own French-English example is the best test case because it turns the abstract monopoly claim into an actual inference. He presents it as one of his empirical argumentation devices, under the heading "French data is English data is Japanese data". The question is whether evidence from French translations can help decide the analysis of English *any* (Reiss, 2026, sec. 5.3.3).

English *any* occurs in negative-polarity environments[1] and in free-choice uses. Roughly, *I didn't eat any cookies* illustrates the polarity-dependent use: *any* depends on a licensing environment such as negation. *Choose any card* illustrates the free-choice use: any member of the relevant set is permitted. French, in the relevant standard examples, uses forms such as *rien* in negative contexts and *n'importe quoi* in free-choice contexts. Reiss uses the French contrast to argue that English has two forms pronounced *any*, and then asks what licenses French evidence for English. His answer is UG.

Projectibility-first reconstruction keeps the useful inference while denying the monopoly. The target isn't "English as such"; it's the analysis of English *any*: whether a single surface form realizes one lexical-semantic item or two. The comparandum is the functional contrast between polarity-dependent uses and free-choice uses. The language-internal realizations include English *any*, French *rien*, and French *n'importe quoi*. Classification of English *any* as one item or two is exactly what has to be argued for; it can't be read off the French split.

Diagnostics remain local. Negative contexts, questions, conditionals, downward-entailing contexts, and related environments diagnose the negative-polarity side; downward-entailing contexts are

[1] I use "negative-polarity" here for the licensing environments, not as a commitment to "NPI" as a settled lexical kind. The *Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* expands "NPI" as "negatively oriented polarity-sensitive item" and treats the relevant environments as including non-affirmative contexts rather than simply negative ones (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 822–838).

environments where truth over a larger set carries truth over a relevant subset. Free-choice readings, modal environments, and indifference readings diagnose the other side. Translation into French is a diagnostic cue because it shows that the semantic-pragmatic contrast can be lexicalized separately, not because it transfers a French category into English.

A simpler case shows why that restriction matters. French expresses age with *avoir*: *j'ai cinquante-sept ans*. English has *have*, numerals, and *years*, and *I have five years* is grammatical when it describes a duration, as in time remaining until retirement. But as a response to *How old are you?*, **I have fifty-seven years* is ungrammatical on the intended age-predication reading. French evidence can bear on English here only after the target is named: age predication, duration expression, calque, bilingual transfer, or translation practice. The French construction is a cue to a contrast, not a licence to import the French analysis into English.

Turkish evidentiality sharpens the reductio. Turkish has a grammaticalized indirect-evidential form in its verbal system, commonly associated with inference, report, or discovery rather than direct witnessing (Aikhenvald, 2004; Göksel & Kerslake, 2005). English can translate such clauses with a simple past such as *Ali left*, adding *apparently*, *I hear*, or *I saw it happen* only when information source matters. Turkish evidence doesn't show that English *left* is secretly two past forms, one witnessed and one inferential. It shows that Turkish grammaticalizes a contrast English may express lexically, pragmatically, or not at all.

Reiss needn't bite that bullet. He can say that Turkish evidence becomes relevant only when a UG theory and English-internal diagnostics make the projected evidential contrast independently plausible. That concession is the point. Once target, diagnostics, scope, and defeaters do the licensing, the bare UG postulate isn't doing the work. A substantive UG theory may be one warrant; it isn't the monopoly licence.

Reiss's polarity case needs the same caution. Polarity-item classifications aren't exhausted by a single label or a simple binary contrast. Hoeksema's survey of negative polarity items shows many distributional classes across questions, comparatives, conditionals, universals, *only*, superlatives, and related environments: the patterns aren't random, but neither do they reduce to one strong/weak taxonomy (Hoeksema, 2012). Reiss's example needs the sort of item-sensitive distributional profile that a projectibility audit demands. The label "NPI" doesn't do the transfer work.

French creates a second problem. French *rien* is entangled with negative-quantifier and negative concord item behaviour, not simply with the behaviour of English NPI *any* as treated in classic polarity accounts (Chierchia, 2013; Ladusaw, 1979). If *rien* is made to stand for the polarity-dependent member of an English split, then a classification has already been imported: negative quantification, negative concord, polarity sensitivity, and free choice have been lined up in the way the argument requires. That's not a bridge principle. It's the very classificatory shortcut Reiss says his opponents aren't entitled to make. The inference has been built by assuming the destination classification it's supposed to license.

Mere parsimony can't be the ordering relation. The ordering relation has to explain why the observed distributions and the projected analysis are co-available. In this case, the candidate relation is compositional and distributional: polarity-dependent readings are tied to licensing environments, while free-choice readings carry modal or indifference force in environments where that licensing relation is absent. If English-internal evidence shows that those two dependency profiles behave differently across environments, a split analysis gains support. If it doesn't, French remains a prompt rather than a licence.

Evidence itself doesn't stabilize the inference. Overt splits in other languages and English distributional contrasts are diagnostics. Candidate stabilizers would have to be defended separately: recurrent functional pressure to keep polarity-dependent indefinites apart from free-choice expressions, a diachronic pathway that repeatedly separates the two, a processing or acquisition pressure, or a grammatical theory that predicts the split. Without such support, the French evidence has cue status. With English-internal diagnostics and a defended recurrence profile, it may become a scoped bridge. It isn't a robust bridge on Reiss's example alone.

Defeaters matter just as much. The warrant weakens if English-internal diagnostics fail to separate the uses, if a unified semantics predicts both distributions without residue, if the French contrast turns out to reflect idiosyncratic lexicalization rather than the relevant profile, or if dialect and register variation in French undermine the claimed contrast. Reiss himself notes complications involving negative concord, French dialect variation, and the mismatch between standard written French and spoken varieties. A projectibility-first account treats those complications as defeaters or scope conditions, not as footnotes to a universal permission to transfer.

That reconstruction gives a verdict different from the bare UG postulate. Reiss treats the French data as licensed for English by UG. Projectibility demotes the French data to a cue until the support profile and failure conditions are supplied. A substantive UG theory may supply some of that missing structure, but then it's functioning as one first-order warrant under audit. The general postulate alone hasn't licensed the transfer. Reiss's worked case needs the very machinery his monopoly conclusion tries to reserve for UG.

## 7 Historical Comparison as a Non-UG Warrant

That audit of French-English *any* is deliberately severe: it shows that Reiss's own example doesn't reach robust-bridge status on the evidence supplied. But non-UG warrants needn't stop at cue level. Historical-comparative linguistics provides a familiar case in which evidence from one language bears on another because the licence is causal-historical rather than UG-theoretic.

Here, the target is a causal-historical pattern in a family of languages: an inherited form, a regular sound change, a morphological alternation, a construction, or a subgroup relation. The profile is common descent under transmission and change. That shouldn't be alien to Reiss's 'linguists'. They needn't infer UG from phylogeny, but they rely on comparative and phylogenetic inference in biology whenever the Human Language Faculty is treated as an evolved, inherited human trait. That makes descent an ordinary inference-supporting relation, not a suspect one. If comparative inference can support claims about inherited biological traits, the same general evidential form can't be ruled out when the inherited material is linguistic: sounds, forms, morphological patterns, and constructions. The substrate differs, and so do the diagnostics and defeaters; the evidential logic isn't UG-specific.

For historical comparison, diagnostics include recurring cognate sets, systematic sound correspondences, shared irregular morphology, chronology, geography, and independent evidence about borrowing and contact (Fortson, 2004). The ordering relation is causal: daughter systems inherit, transform, lose, borrow, analogize, and reanalyse material from earlier systems. Evidence from Sanskrit, Greek, Latin, Gothic, or Old Irish can bear on a reconstruction not because UG says all languages are comparable, but because those languages are historically related in ways that constrain what counts as a good projection.

A correspondence set such as Latin *pater*, Greek *patēr*, Sanskrit *pitar-*, and Gothic *fadar* doesn't merely record resemblance. Together with many comparable sets, it supports a reconstruction of an inherited kinship term and a correspondence profile in which Germanic *f* aligns with non-Germanic *p* under independently motivated sound change, here the familiar Grimm's Law correspondence (Fortson, 2004). Evidence from Gothic can bear on the reconstruction, and the reconstruction can bear on the analysis of the Latin, Greek, and Sanskrit forms, because transfer is mediated by a causal-historical profile.

This warrant has explicit scope limits. It licenses evidential travel within a family or contact history; it doesn't license arbitrary transfer from any language to any other. Its defeaters are also familiar: chance resemblance, borrowing, areal diffusion, analogy, expressive vocabulary, semantic drift, defective attestation, and chronology that makes inheritance impossible. Those defeaters are part of the warrant. They make the inference scientific. A claim about inherited structure can be localized, demoted, or rejected when the correspondence profile fails.

Background conditions of several kinds can matter to historical explanation. A UG theory might constrain possible sound systems, learnability, or grammar change; articulatory and perceptual facts may explain why particular sound changes are plausible. Those constraints help shape the space of possible changes, but they don't license evidential transfer by themselves. The licence still comes from the reconstruction profile.

Historical comparison is bounded, but that bounded success is enough to defeat the monopoly claim. Reiss's motivating examples include horizontal transfer: Japanese evidence on English, or typological evidence across unrelated languages, where common descent is unavailable by construction. The historical case settles one issue and leaves another open. Non-UG transfer principles exist, so UG can't be the exclusive licence for linguistic evidential travel.

For unrelated-language transfer specifically, the French *any* audit supplies a method and a demotion verdict. Haspelmath and Croft discipline comparison and classification, but a successful horizontal non-UG warrant would need its own support profile, held-out projections, and defeaters. The claim here is the negative one Reiss denies: UG has no monopoly. The stronger positive typological case is a further project rather than a hidden premise.

## 8 Public and Distributed Linguistic Objects

So far, the paper has answered the evidential half of the monopoly claim. Reiss's ontological restriction supplies the other half. His chapter treats I-languages as the proper objects of theoretical linguistics and presses an individuation worry against public languages: a standard such as Standard English isn't a compact mental object, and it didn't travel to the moon with Neil Armstrong. The joke points to an individuation challenge. If a public language isn't located in one head, what makes it one object rather than a loose label for many practices?

A projectibility reply individuates public, community-level, and normatively regimented objects by the projections they support and the failure conditions they accept. Their tractability can come from maintenance, uptake, correction, transmission, and institutionalization; their projectibility is shown when those mechanisms support stated projections under declared failure conditions.

Stainton's defence of public languages makes this point without denying mental grammars (Stainton, 2011). The study of public languages can be viable if the object is understood as a humanly individuated system whose evidence base includes deployment, uptake, and psychological facts. Santana's pluralist treatment of language also cuts against the idea that one privileged language-object settles all legitimate inquiry; the remaining question is which projections each object licenses, and when evidence about one target is being made to travel to another without warrant (Reynolds, 2026c; Santana, 2016).

Reiss's remarks about Standard English and public languages depend on a serious individuation worry. But the moon example proves too much. Armstrong didn't bring NASA command authority, the flight plan, radio protocol, or mission time to the lunar surface as compact objects either. Still, his actions there were partly constituted by those distributed norms and institutions. Without them, planting a flag, reading a checklist, reporting to Houston, and taking a "small step" wouldn't have been the acts they were. The transport test is the wrong test for distributed objects: it turns a trip to the moon into an ontological filter that would erase much of what made the trip intelligible.

That projection question is concrete for public standards. Model-theoretic syntax makes room for formally characterizing public constructs without treating them as mental grammars (Pullum & Scholz, 2001); sociolinguistic work on standardization and enregisterment, the process by which forms become socially recognized as tied to registers or identities, supplies mechanisms for norm uptake and public recognizability (Agha, 2005; Milroy & Milroy, 1999). These literatures point to a public target whose projections concern correction, acceptance, institutional uptake, and style-shifting, not individual competence as such.

Here, the argument answers the ontological half of Reiss's restriction rather than adding another case of crosslinguistic evidential transfer. For non-I-language targets, the same evidential demand applies, but the support may be social-practical rather than genetic. Calling only I-language "language" doesn't make the other targets disappear.

Varieties give a compact test case. Register, dialect, and discourse community can be analysed as conditioning structures: participant expectation conditioned primarily on situation, ascription, or identification (Reynolds, 2026b). The claim is projective. Knowing enough about the conditioning state should help predict likely forms, and hearing the forms should help infer the conditioning state. When those predictions fail, the variety claim can be localized or demoted rather than disappearing into metaphysical fog.

Standard written English fits the same template. Its target is an edited public standard, not every English speaker's mental grammar or every English utterance. The projected expectations concern spelling, punctuation, selected morphosyntactic forms, correction practices, uptake in institutional settings, and the treatment of deviations as errors, choices, or markers of another register. The diagnostics include style guides, editorial intervention, school assessment, institutional documents, dictionaries, usage manuals, and corpora of edited prose.

For this target, correction, publication, assessment, and uptake help stabilize the edited standard and support projections about future applications of it. The relation is social-practical: the warrant runs through maintained practices, without requiring a hidden mental mechanism.

For example, evidence from style guides, corrected student prose, copy-edited publications, and edited corpora can support projections about how *its/it's*, *between you and I*, or *who/whom* will be treated in academic prose. It doesn't support the same projection about spontaneous speech, a speaker's I-language, or every digital text. The target controls the inference.

Schooling, publishing, examination, professional editing, reference works, and repeated public use stabilize the profile. The scope is edited and institutionally answerable prose. It isn't casual speech, all written English, all Englishes, or the competence of every individual speaker. Defeaters include divergent institutional norms, stable acceptance of a formerly corrected form, failure to predict held-out edited texts, or evidence that a supposed standard feature tracks genre, medium, or identity rather than the standard.

The template licenses some projections and blocks others. It explains why evidence from a style guide may bear on an edited newspaper sentence but not on a child's spontaneous speech; why corpus frequencies in unedited social media may be diagnostic for one target and misleading for another; and why public-language inquiry doesn't need to pretend that public standards are located in one head. A distributed standard is disciplined when its target, support profile, scope, and defeaters are declared.

Those are projective claims, not slogans. Uptake, correction, transmission, and institutional maintenance may be stabilizing backgrounds, parts of the profile, or mere diagnostics depending on the projection target. A public-language argument has to say which role they play. That demand is a strength of the alternative, because it imposes the same discipline on non-UG objects that Reiss rightly imposes on crosslinguistic inference.

## 9 Conclusion

Crosslinguistic inference requires bridge principles; it does *not* require Chomskyan Universal Grammar. Reiss's paper is strongest when it insists that categories are theory-mediated and that evidence doesn't travel for free. It's weakest where it treats that methodological burden as if it had only one possible answer.

Historical reconstruction also shows why the projectibility claim is realist rather than merely instrumental. Reconstructed proto-forms aren't convenience labels. They're posits constrained by converging correspondences, causal order, independent chronology, and defeaters. The successful projection is concrete: inherited correspondences are expected under causal-genealogical scope, while French evidence about *any* remains cue-level without independent English-internal support. Public standards and typological comparanda are less compact objects, but they answer to the same demand: declare the projections they support and the failures they accept.

Projectibility-first work accepts the burden and raises it. Every proposed evidential transfer has to declare the target, the support profile, and the failure conditions. Chomskyan I-language inquiry can meet that demand for its own targets. So can non-UG inquiries, when their warrants specify what carries the inference and where it stops. Reiss hasn't shown that LINGUISTS need UG to do linguistics.

Projectibility is defeasible too. The account would fail if non-UG warrants kept collapsing into cue-level prompts, if proposed profiles failed on held-out cases, if ordering relations merely renamed the data, or if social and typological targets yielded no projections beyond their diagnostics. Those are the right risks. They make evidential travel inspectable: what carries the inference, where it stops, and what would break it. UG may answer that demand for some Chomskyan targets. It doesn't own the demand, and it isn't the condition of possibility for linguistic evidence.

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